

The bell rang two weeks before summer break, letting grade schoolers bleed onto the pavement and into the buses. A couple of "fuck you's" and "suck my dick's" spilled out of the windows and stained the teachers who were attending to the students as they climbed into the rumbling caravan. One of the buses backfired and crept in first gear, leaving a blackball of burnt oil for the other screaming machines to punch through.

Mark had watched the children being dropped off and picked up for the last week and a half and only stopped watching three days before the night letter had arrived from the school board. It explained, "Since Mark had not been able to attend school these last two weeks, making a total of five weeks missed from school, he will not be promoted with his fifth-grade class." He had listened for silence to lay down behind his mother's bedroom door.

"Almost time for dinner," he thought miserably, as he heard his sister and brother click the TV knob on a dilapidated black and white Zenith. They were pretending electricity was still running through it. Rachel and Jason pounded their butts on the end of the sofa, causing it to seesaw on the only legs that sat in the center of it. Mark pulled himself up from the base of the refrigerator and stood in front of it. He shifted his weight to the right and wedged his hand into the pocket of his bellbottom. His fingers solemnly prodded through the Web's of thread that had cocooned the pulp pebbles of homework.

"If Mom gets up, go sit out back," Mark said as the streams of light from the window bounced about with aimless ambitions to illuminate through the suffocating storm. "Get the candles." He dropped the tangled cocoons free from his pocket. They sat on the breakfast bar that separated the kitchen from the living room. "I'll be back,"

Mark said to Rachel and Jason, who were wasting no time in relocating to the screened-in porch. The wind rolled up his pants leg, inflating his shirt as he stepped outside and stop quietly clicked the door shut. He sprang off the stairless porch and cut toward the conglomeration of restaurants and failed businesses that sat in the center of town. The houses in the neighborhood only defining differences were addresses.

Mark had had difficulty distinguishing his house from the others when he at first moved there from St. Louis. That was until he noticed that most of them had bicycles with big wheels strewn in the unkempt yards and his had the Edsel. He spent many nights in the Edsel with his siblings while there mother had some drinks in one of the many Midwestern bars that they leapfrogged between interstate rest stops and towns. The previous two weeks had started with haunting normality as Mark made his way home from school to find that the Edsel had been parked in the dirt driveway. All the windows had been left down excluding the driver side window.

Mark felt his heart beating heavily making his neck throb as he slowly crept by the still-running car. The turn signal had blinked from necessity to negligence, smacking orange against the paper bag covered books. The class of '90 sticker metallicly rattled off a couple of different colors seeming to say, "no it can't be."

"Oh, but he can," replied the turn signal.

"Why now?" Mark asked diving into the front seat with the required reach for turning off the signal and key. His eyes narrowed and cropped in the black high-heeled shoe that stood toe to toe with him.

"Confidentially, I think we've got a problem," tissue had exclaimed along with the other inanimate clues. One by one, they argued for balance in his arms, as he quickly snatched up the trail of clothing that led to the front porch.

The sun pushed his chalk line shadow through the open door. "Diana?" He hissed for his mother. The room screamed with the sound of water that gushed in the sink. A plastic bowl loft along like a ship with leftover corn flakes as passengers. "Diana?" He continued to whisper, while he floated through the door into the kitchen to kill the water. It squeezed off squealing and solemnly knocking to a finale. He poured the close onto the counter beside the gurgling sink. He sifted through the clothes. White blouse, gray skirt, pantyhose, and a shoe. "Diana?" Of He discovered the counterpart to the pair that lay discarded next to the open door of her bedroom. The site of skin was unmistakable against the dingy gray, thickly painted walls. He stepped closer to survey the damage. His mother droop frozen on the side of the bed, wearing only a bra and clutching her underwear in her right hand.

"Diana." Her head snapped away after seeing marks shredded shoes approach. She cowered as if she were pressing herself against an imaginary wall and intended to climb it.

"That's OK" he said, trying to shut her gasping mouth. "No, it's best if you, you keep...SHHH," his voice trembled with mounting anger. "Yes, I know you're sorry," his words pounced on the part of the monotonous dialogue that had snapped on and off for the good part of six years. "And I know you won't do it again. I know... I know... I know..." He left her mouth to wander breathlessly for her lines. Her red hair was a harsh

contrast to the black curls that sprung from between her legs. It was, instead, a perfect match to the pasty shards of mascara that had sliced into her painted cheeks. The room was filled with bottles and boxes of base, lipstick, powders. She had all the quantity qualifications for a Mary Kay representative. A couple of full of cases base sat stacked on a broken air conditioner outside her window. The pane had been covered with a contact paper picture of the sun setting in the Caribbean. An open bottle of champagne had sank to its neck, next to the empty lawn chair looking like a safari that had run into quicksand.

Mark walked over to her and slipped his hands under her arms. Diana collapsed per hundred pound frame on to his undeveloped shoulders and cried. Mark's hands bounced down the bones of her spine searching for the hook to her bra. It clicked with hardly any effort and shot halfway down her motionless arms from the wait of her large breasts. He temporarily lifted her to make a gap for his hand to quickly grab the baby blue electrical blanket from underneath her and let gravity take her to bed. She shrank between the swallowing waves of covers and islands of skin dissolved at high tide. Mark peered outside of the room as the last bit of beaches escaped into the darkness.

He shuffled through the living room and shoveled up the clothes from next to the now empty sink. His vision waved with fuel fumes as he had heard gravel being crushed from underneath a slowing car. "God fuckin' dammit," He said as the muscles in his jaw and stomach fluttered with tension. He sprinted to the closet in his mother's room. Mark through the close over the cases of cosmetics to splash into the bamboo-beaded closet. His right hand ran through to the shapes as his eyes watched for the stretching shadows to

invade the living room. "Fuck?!" His diaphragm had prepared a scream, but his mouth only allowed a throat smoldering hiss as he scrambled toward the shoe that still waited in the doorway. He kicked it behind him and closed the room. The punches of the closing hatches of the VW bus startled his last escaping hopes that someone was using his driveway to only turnaround.

"Hello? Hello?" A voice called patiently from outside. His breath fell from underneath him as he tried to reasonably respond only to sound dreamy.

"Hello, Miss Jones? Could I have a moment with you?"

"She's in her room asleep. She's sick." Mark called from inside the house. He walked toward the door.

"Mark, maybe I could talk to you, that is, if you don't mind." His face fell lax with devastation, as he was surprised with the clarity in which she used his name. "Hello, Rumplestilskin," she attempted to lighten the situation as he dropped out of the doorway. Rachel and Jason scaled the side of the porch with their lunch boxes banging.

"Go inside." He cleared a path for them and tried not to look anywhere in particular.

"Mark, how are you today?" She said, stepping to the left to follow the children as they darted out of sight. Her dress looked like a sheet draped over a large piece of furniture. "Mark, I really need to speak with your mother. I was wondering if it would be okay if I were to call tonight, to speak to her."

"Who are you?" He said as an answer more than a question. She mentally stumbled

"I'm sorry." Coming to rest with an impromptu maven voice. "My name is Miss Stafford." Fat ass Jason's voice giggled inside Mark's head. "And I work with Jason and Rachel at the day care center, and when I saw that your mother was quite late to pick up Jason and Rachel..."

"I was just on my way to get them."

"I know Mark but I haven't been able to catch your mother..."

"She's been very..."

"Very sick, I know, but this is not the first time that they have been left to wait. I've been talking with Jason and I was wondering if you could explain... blah... blah... blah... blah... blah..." Marks jaw and heat was pulled to look for Jason in the darkness of the house.

"Explain what?" She stammered.

"Well, do you need food?"

"I hear my mom vomiting. I've got to go." Mark jumped into the house.

"Tell your mother that I need to talk to her as soon as she's... blah... blah... blah,"

The door slammed. She cranked the bus on and crept away.

"What did I tell you!"

"I'm sorry!"

"What did you tell her!"

"I'm sorry!"

"Stop it!"

"Don't Markey, I'm sorry!"

"Shut up!"

"Let go please. I'm sorry Markey... Markey?!"

"Shut up, goddamn it."

"Markey?!"

"Fuck! Stop it...shut up... shut up..."

"I'm sorry.... stop it?!"

"shut up... shut up... shut up... shut up, shut up, shut up, shut up... I'm-I'm sorry Jason.. Jason please I'm sorry, I'm sorry. Fuck, I'm sorry. Please. What the fuck?!" A drop of rain speared loose from the gray heavens and smacked Mark swollen eye.

"Fuck!" He ran faster.

The smell of pizza met him four blocks from the restaurant. Another block, he thought and then cross the alley. His arm stopped aching three days after this routine had been successfully established as a way of getting dinner. Almost there, he continued to coach himself. The lightning startled a step which he made up between the space before the thunder. Mark scurried out of the obstacle course of trash cans and into the alley. He slowed to a trot, as the grayscale of the storm biased itself to the shade of night.

The bug light cradled the back entrance to the restaurant and a jaundice glow. His stomach winced with hunger as the smell blanketed the town. It caused him to pinch over in hopes to alleviate the painful rumbling. "One more block and you can stop." His body nor the coach and walked in. Mark slid down the wall across from the door. Five minutes had cut by, leading him time to catch his breath and concentrate on ignoring the

hunger. "I can't believe it hasn't rained," he murmured staring at the explosions in the sky.

The door cracked open. Two large white bags of food bounce like vagabond's out into the chicken wire bins. Mark hastened to move till the scraping had quit in the door closed. The slightly translucent trash bags visually empty the red letter pizza box to Mark's eyes. He quickly alleyooped it over the barricade, squatted, tumbled and ran. The petting promise of the storm was relayed from tar covered roofs through the periscopic gutters to Mark's ears making him turn to see the waving curtain of rain. Mark yanked the box free from the shredded womb. The drowning sound of water swallowed his breathing and foot falls as the wave rolled over him instantly soaking his clothes.

"Fuck!" Mark said discovering the impossibility of practical site. "Fuck!" Circles of soaked cardboard rapidly dilapidated the pizza box. "Fuck?!" He shoved it under his shirt sending pie to the downside of the box tripping him into a puddle larger than himself elbows down. He had commented on two occasions that this had been the moment he had stopped crying over physical pain. That he stood only with smallest intentions to walk in a circle and took to the needy at inspection of wounds. Mark lifted an invisible barbell to his chest giving admission to the blistering volley that pelted out the gravel from inside his forearms. He would dead lift the mass of pain within a trembling sentiment of 12 volt to his genitals until he seen only blood and very few pieces of asphalt.

The bucket of confetti rain had ended. The cursing chef who pointed with simultaneous karate chops at the 12th torn bag was easily washed out by the

embarrassing bright mustard sunset and cars swinging ditch water off and on the sidewalk. Illuminated from two elbows of red comets, rain thinned blood painted tales to his bruised wrists, in his vault determined escape.

The measured dissociation from the knowledge of what he had done blocks away characterized his walk to a any other kid veneer. Staring up between concrete sidewalk and the sky Mark masticated breath fully the degree of flat empty branches to the fresh emerald leafs. The warmth inside his shirt was convivial to the breeze for his blurred goose pimpled arms. Mark sucked water from his chin stretched collar and huffed his obligatory computations of how many steps taken from the exiting of the alley, to the number of viewable perpendicular objects.

"356... Separate pieces of sidewalk..." He chewed his compulsory hypotheses between fabric and teeth. The callow role of the shoulder that opened a bone bound window for his hand to squirt back through his sleeve stopped discomfited. "What am I going to do." He pleaded to one of his shoes. The foot out of focus took a limp exit back toward town for the blacktop of the grocery store parking lot. The body blue corrugated co-op sign was prudently discussed as municipality timed dusk coughed halogen throughout the streets.

Mark kneed through a dandelion trench between the back of the fuel station in the tombstone staggered speed bumps that lined the parking lot edge to discourage driving to only one entrance. Mark began to blast truck sounds and placed the nose of his thumbs within the cheeks of his fingers. He sped by the shelved propane tanks and continued the rotating rumble of air that gave the sound of shifting gear that he would hit with sequence

slot machine polls. The after work crowd bundled at the entrance. (Drug company employees.) Mark drove three person deep then reduced his engine to yell behind him. "I'm just going in, why... mom?" Principally calling to the wind winking bathroom doors on the back of the gas station. Mark turned with scorn and mischievously weaved as being closed upon by a lumbering giant's hand. Dispensed into the store the air-conditioning differentiated the dry in the damp with a shiver. Mark a few inches higher than the check cashing insecurely doodle covered counter proceeded to demonstrate his poolside restraint to run. He stopped, turned and took some backwards steps on his heels facing the entrance. "Why. I'm just going down here. Why." Behaving under his age Mark pouted a few steps to the shopping carts next to the automated entry. "Okay!" Excitedly. "Okay... I'll be just down here." He jump turned into the cereal aisle. Mark's wipe of staunch focus down the pitch of anthropomorphism could be easily revealed to the half dozen shoppers if not for their examining the cylinder of pastel choices. Spotting the pepperoni Marks peripheral puppet prancing levitation slung him unwillingly into the longest open cooler that lined the back of the store. Not wanting to hobble he rubbed the place where he had bumped himself on the chrome lip. "Mom." Mark gave sacramental slaps of vision over each shoulder. "Mom." He decided the best direction and assiduously reached for the coin laid vacuum sealed package of pepperoni. "Can I get two. Mom! Mom..." Open mouth he plucked one off the wall of meat. Strafing the food filled warehouse he located the opening to the inexpensive toys section and bolted with manifested apprehension. He relaxed his turret, stood at the crack in between the magazine display and a rack of neon guns. Hiding a portion of himself he slid the food

into his pants and inspected for witnesses calmly. Pinching over without dislodging the goods from his waistband Mark chose a Caucasian pigment ball from one of the three primary color wire bends. He bounced it twice, rubbed the seam, hopped as many times and stood to feel if the triage caused any movement. Mark read the covers of the radio control hobbyist magazines that sat at eye level.

Urgent slaps of naked feet running, several partitions away broke his jaw loose with the blood that was elucidated from his face and haunting zephyrs paraded over him as the chain of heel firm foot falls grew. A roller coaster of bones that climbed to his skull determined the limit of his activity to a shocked sober conveyance that held through the whip of his head. Blinking the rest of the skeleton in line with the lighthouse of his gaze that tried to make out through the fog of disbelief at the sight of his naked self sprinting toward him with the expression of terror and grossly hopeful relief. 14 years later Mark would explain to his wife that what he had most feared was how dirty his feet were. Jumping from out of immobility to adulation as he bowed his back from the tackle and leapt out the entrance to the toy section. He did not look back.

The Melanocyte in his white knuckles, soaked the blood from out of his heart to return to the color of the ball that he gripped hard enough to have hurt his arm and the inc swirl of blush that pumped to his cheeks emerged as a apple core in the snow. A bark from his drying shoe was amplified by the hall of cans that he turned into pass the packaged meat. Not slowing Mark studied the top of the shelves for boxes of cereal peeking over the fruit cocktail wall stacked containers. Going to his toes to see a yellow

trptych of the back of a chrome spoon with winner printed on it like a tattoo on one half of an ass sitting down in an oversized bowl of gold droppings.

He checked the three patrons that were in shouting distance as they looked over bouillon cubes, Chile and leveling baskets. With no hesitation he jumped back from the defending cocktail and released with enough drive to hit several boxes to the floor. Inspection from the shoppers nodded out of inactiveness to find the direction of the noise. Mark became smaller and undeterred from the path to the front of the store. He could see the night manager freshly showered look for an opening between the empty registers and descend straight to the noise as a white collared ghost. "I can carry it mom." Mark whispered again. "I've got this mom." The rehearsal continued past the grains and the one-hour photo.

"Can't you help me with the dog food." A woman wearing purple sweat pants over her green high school basketball T-shirt slung her purse on her butt like a saddle and was less than round when she bent down to shove as much of the 50 pound bag on the lower level of her full cart. "I'll do it myself." She continued her complaining. "You don't help me with anything." She raised the volume at a teenage man who revealed from under a embroidered sports cap his dumbfounded embarrassment, at what appeared to him as his mother's first-time to double over and fight to cage the dog food. Mark gave a minute lien while he banked left from out of the corner of batteries and prepackaged firewood. He birthed himself between the woman's wagging tail and the beginning of grocery deliveries against the window at the front of the co-op. They slumped on each other from the swamp of vegetables and the defrosting perishables.

"Put your foot behind the wheel." The mother moaned at her son who scrambled recklessly for a place to put his headphones that was admitting mouse screams. Mark judged the visual mass of each delivery and quickly grab the last one in the lump line. Pressing the paper bag against his belly to hold the warmed pepperoni in place and being careful not to show the address on the receipt that had been stapled just below the serrated rim, he said defiantly.

"I want to carry it!" Watching the peripheral promotional warn linoleum print of vines vanish into real collie flower under his nose acted as a blinder to eliminate all other focus but the glass hall of vending machines. Mark assured loudly. "I won't drop it!" Then quietly. "25 feet to go."

"Just put the rest of the stuff there, inside the cart... inside the cart! Right there... right there! god!" The woman's criticism brayed from growing distance and fresh air puffing from the open-door. Music cursed with volume in the atrium of sentinel soda machines and plastic toy dispensers. Mark's spherical reflection licked the suspended gold trinket pupils in the froth of containers that lay inoperable to watch his travel through their small domain. In a long stride, that shocked Mark to how close he came to fall, lifted the child's size sac back into his bear hug in brace and left.

"Potatoes?" He said in doubt. "Boiling water, right?" A primer painted 4-wheel with exposed rust at the back tire well made use of the wet lot to fishtail into a empty parking gap where the dearth of available space shrank with incoming traffic. The running bond pattern of cinder blocks paraded Marks silhouette that squeezed nimbly

through the impediment of bumpers that pushed in and out from the store wall like a accordion.

"That will keep it from getting wet." He announced at the placement of the bag on his toes in the burnt out storefront along his escape. Mark lifts his shirt and pulls the pepperoni from his belly to sheathe the thin package inside the leaning parcel. "Shit... I think..." Huffing through his nose. "I could..." He shook his head. "Walked in their and taken this...." Mark blushing. "Stupid. Polling pants." Creeping to the next words he relayed the point-to-point activities. "Grabbing bag, time to leave..." He sighed.

The leaf pounded dirt roads behind a number of the houses in the neighborhood, had only so many paces between aborted vehicles that Mark would rest on with the extent surviving sack of food when his languid darkly scabbed limbs needed to hang. Mark credited the siding of the deflated inner tube dinosaur on the back of his roof for the rejuvenation in his step. He kicked the wood slat privacy fence door open to his patchy yard. "Rachel. Jason." Mark called for his brother and sister.

A door of a man impeded the naked 100 W bulb that clicked a semicolon on the center of the living room ceiling from reaching Marks 4 1/2 ft scaffold. Mark skipped his vision to the house through the scallop that shined beneath the man's armpit "I'm sorry. I have the wrong house...for delivery." Mark displaced operatives from the certainty at the unpaid electrical bills that he had taken the time to sort by month, stack and squash down into the kitchen drawer. The man's petting palm rippled across the detection of the outdoor switch.

"Is this him?" The door spoke softer than his shoulders that poised the rain coat he wore high enough to cause his neck to optically vanish.

"Mark, right? Let me through." Another man morphed as a second appendage. Ripping off and plopping on the porch he swiped nonexistent dust from his britches. "Did you see that, I almost fell." He shared a stiff avuncular grin. "Just sit right there. Turn on the porch light!"

"It's dead." Three quick clicks continued the corroboration. "The bulb must be dead." The weight rustled out from Marks num circle where the groceries had a moment before nested.

"Thank you for giving that to me." He announced as his partner gave two maternal shakes of his pointer where the empty socket poked five vinyl siding slats above the light switch. The efficacy of Marks manikin grip ended without communicating to his arms the time to lower. "What did you get here? Let's see. I feel some potatoes. Collie flower. I like collie flower too. Well starfruit." Twisting back. "Mark likes starfruit. Capers? What were you planning?" Mark's brow quivered without resting. Losing the teeth from his previous smile the man perched the temperate bag on his hip and bent down to give Mark a slight urge with a push of his elbow. "Time to go inside. We need to talk. Well it's probably better that you listen." He used the words to announce their entrance. He scrutinized Marks clothes from the back without suspicion and showed as much to the only other adult in the light shrunken room. She had sat with her back inches away from the television that gave proscenium seeding to Rachel and Jason on the down side of the unbalanced couch. Mark was ushered to the sofa and when

sat, Rachel reached to prevent herself from rolling over Jason from the weight shift. She had a quick but truthful expression of pain from slipping her fingers into the crevasse of worn pillows and had decided instead of putting her hand in her mouth in front of mixed company it rolled to a fist for her chin to lean on.

"Are you okay." Mesmerized by her white blue eyes, that gleamed concern, Mark and Rachel, confused to who was the intended listener, nodded together. "Where were you Mark." She bit at him confused. "Where have you been."

"Who are you." He stung a quake to her straight back posture.

"He went to go get them some food. Or he has a job as a delivery boy." The man melodramatically previewed the receipt that had clawed its place six staples sturdy. Seeing that this is not the same street, on the ticket... hell..." He stopped serving his platter oval eyes of a far sided reader and cocked his ear up to listen if he had in his comic vanity snitched. "Hell..."

"Stop cursing." She clamped her lips to preview the attended affect that he did not adopt.

"Hell I think he stole it." Dryly. "He's a hero."

"I'm your Aunt Molly." Her thin white finger pointed and hither for the men's readied response. "This is Dean and that is Jeff." Dean leaned on the bar next to the groceries and shrugged.

"Hi guys."

Jeff came around proceeded by loud walking to give each of the kids a handshake.

"Rachel right." Jeff's square fingers dwarfed Rachel and Jason's hands. While acutely aware of his size with a tea serving pinch to Marks brother and sister Jeff's greeting left Mark with ringing digits.

"Our aunt?!" Mark demanded. Jeff scurried from his introduction and as well as Dean watched for Molly's next exchange.

"I haven't seen your mother and a longtime. I wasn't sure where you were. Mark you and I have met. You were so little. And you and I... Jason, Rachel... we just met today." Molly reached for her nose and compressed the pain of crying.

"Where's my mother." Mark uttered without moving his lips.

"She's in her bedroom." The pressure had stopped her tears.

"Oh." Mark replied uncertain.

"She's resting." Doubtfully. "I brought some gifts. I wasn't sure what to get you. You can look at it later." She knotted alone. "You must be hungry. Guys... I saw a pizza place when we came into town or maybe, a diner... somewhere..."